"Hindi imposition"—another example of central overreach, which is already costing Tamil Nadu its rightful funds. The combination of delimitation and the NEP's language mandate threatens to deepen the North-South divide.

So, how will Stalin's aggressive campaign unfold? Analysts, led by Christophe Jaffrelot in the study, 'India—The Challenge of Contrasted Regional Dynamics', published by the Paris-based Institut Montaigne, highlight the country's deep regional disparities in infrastructure, industry, and social welfare. Their analysis suggests that the debate will centre on two key issues. First, the widening North-South divide will escalate tensions. Second, Narendra Modi's economic policies—largely modelled on Gujarat's development strategy—will come under increasing scrutiny, especially when contrasted with Tamil Nadu's alternative approach, which emphasises inclusivity and human capital development. As economic distress deepens, with rising unemployment and an increasingly vulnerable lower-middle class, Tamil Nadu's success story may gain traction, challenging the dominance of the 'Gujarat model' and reshaping India's economic discourse. "Stalin's ability to rally diverse regional forces under the banner of federalism strengthens his position as a champion of equitable representation," says B.V. Muralidhar, chairman, Board of Studies, Department of Political Science, Sri Venkateswara University.

THE DMK'S FOCUS ON THE DELIMITATION DEBATE IS ALSO A STRATEGIC MOVE AHEAD OF THE TAMIL NADU ELECTION, NOW JUST A YEAR AWAY

An electoral plank?

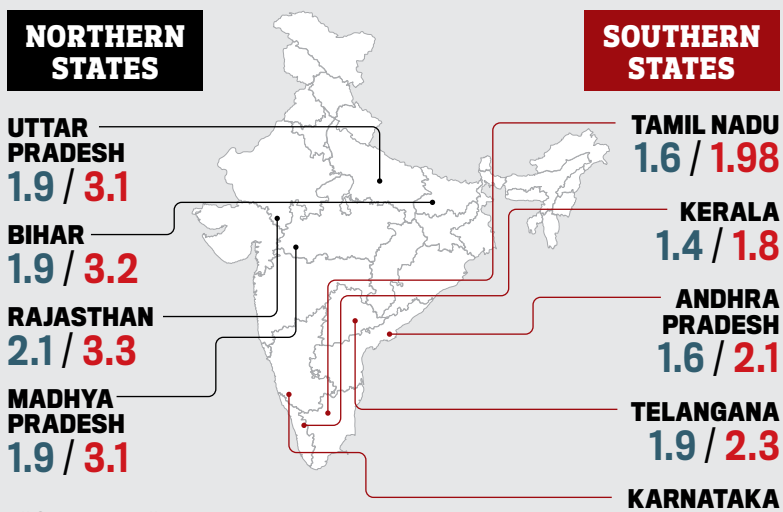
Political analysts argue that the DMK's renewed focus on the delimitation debate is a strategic move ahead of the Tamil Nadu assembly election, now less than a year away. It aligns with a broader political narrative, inadvertently shaped by the BJP-led Centre through issues like NEP-linked funding, the three-language formula, and the NEET. With the all-party meeting, Stalin is signalling that this isn't just a party concern but a matter of state rights and Tamil identity.

The BJP has surely handed the DMK a potent campaign issue. "The BJP has touched a raw nerve as the new generation of Tamil youth has come to see the DMK and AIADMK as stable governments that deliver on social welfare schemes," says political analyst N. Sathia Moorthy. The DMK has already capitalised on ideological battles—over Hindutva and AIADMK's association with the BJP—winning three consecutive elections under Stalin, in 2019 and 2024 (LS), and in 2021 (assembly). This time, the BJP leadership has given Stalin another ideological plank on a silver platter: the 'Dravidian model' narrative, including Centre-state relations and social justice. This comes just as Annamalai was aggressively framing the BJP campaign around governance failures—corruption, nepotism, and lawlessness—long seen as the DMK's weak points.

As the delimitation debate intensifies, it is evident that the South's resistance isn't just about numbers—it is about preserving its political voice, economic contributions and federal autonomy. However, before any redrawing of constituencies can take place, the long-delayed Census must first be conducted. With no official timeline for its completion, the delimitation process remains speculative. Until then, the political rhetoric around it will continue to serve as a flashpoint, shaping poll strategies and deepening regional divides in the run-up to the 2026 Tamil Nadu election. ■

UNEVEN REPRESENTATION

Voter registration doesn't always align with population size in a constituency. Northern states, with a higher share of under-18 residents, see lower registration rates, while southern states show greater political engagement. This gives rise to representation disparities. In Uttar Pradesh, an MP represents an average of 3.1 million people, compared to almost 2 million in Tamil Nadu—a gap of 1.1 million. However, the difference in registered voters per constituency is just 300,000



Source: Report of the Technical Group OOn Population Projections 2024-25, ECI